WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

GABON

Africa

Information current as of October 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Libreville / Owendo	Capital and seat of government; Owendo port is the export terminal for the Trans-Gabon Railway, handling manganese and timber	Administration, port logistics, financial services, construction
Nkok Special Economic Zone (GSEZ)	Flagship public-private zone with Arise IIP, reporting €1.6 billion of FDI generated and more than 20,000 jobs; 25-year tax-free operation and 100% fund repatriation	Wood processing, light manufacturing, export industries
Port-Gentil	Oil capital of Gabon and site of a planned LNG plant led by Perenco and Gabon Oil Company, valued at 560 billion CFA francs	Oil and gas, LNG, oilfield services
Moanda / Franceville (Haut-Ogooué)	Heart of manganese mining, where Gabon is the world's second-largest producer, with domestic alloy processing and the Mpassa-Lebombi zone	Manganese mining and processing, metallurgy
Iron ore projects (including Baniaka)	Iron ore production is budgeted to start in 2027 at 1.5 million tonnes, adding a new export line	Mining, rail and port logistics
Ikolo zone (Lambaréné)	Inland GSEZ industrial site operating since 2021, extending the zone model beyond the capital	Wood processing, agro-industry
Trans-Gabon Railway corridor	Main overland link from the interior to Owendo, carrying manganese, timber and goods; upgrades are part of the national investment programme	Rail, logistics, infrastructure

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- ANPI-Gabon (National Agency for the Promotion of Investments), established in 2014, offers a single window covering more than 20 agencies, with company registration in around 48 hours
- 1998 investment code granting foreign companies the same rights as domestic firms, alongside sector codes with customs and tax incentives for mining, forestry, petroleum, agriculture and tourism
- Special Economic Zones operated by GSEZ (Nkok, Ikolo and Mpassa-Lebombi), offering tax-free operation for 25 years, duty-free equipment imports and full repatriation of funds
- CFA franc (XAF) pegged to the euro at €1 = 655.957 FCFA under the BEAC; foreign-exchange transactions above set thresholds require BEAC approval and export proceeds must be repatriated within 150 days

- Production-sharing and partnership routes in petroleum, where the State may hold up to 20% and Gabon Oil Company up to 15% of contracts
- 2019 Mining Code with state participation of 35% in large mining companies, and the 2020 tourism code offering eight-year tax exemptions for tourism investors
- Public-private partnerships for infrastructure, managed through ANPI-Gabon and aligned with the 2026–2030 National Growth and Development Plan (PNCD)

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Gabon in October 2026 has completed its political transition and is pursuing an ambitious investment-led growth agenda. President Brice Clotaire Oligui Nguema was elected in April 2025 under a new Constitution approved by referendum in November 2024, legislative and local elections completed the process in autumn 2025, and the African Union restored Gabon's full participation in April 2025. GDP grew an estimated 3.2% in 2025, and the government's draft 2027 budget projects growth of 4% in 2026 and 4.5% in 2027, driven by the non-oil economy, the start of iron ore production and local processing of wood and manganese. Inflation is low at around 1% (May 2026), and the BEAC cut its policy rate to 4.5% in June 2026. Gabon is the world's second-largest manganese producer, and the 2026–2030 National Growth and Development Plan is backed by a 2026 capital budget of 3,300 billion CFA francs, creating opportunities in infrastructure, mining, energy and agro-industry.

Gabon's main structural task is to put public finances on a sustainable footing while funding this investment programme. Debt and payment arrears have risen, rating agencies have the sovereign in the CCC/Caa range, and the IMF's April 2026 projections put debt at around 86% of GDP in 2026. The authorities are responding: a debt audit completed in September 2026 consolidated the debt stock at 9,525 billion CFA francs, or 68.9% of 2025 GDP on the government's figures, subject to IMF review; a new integrated public financial management system went live in January 2026; and Gabon formally requested an IMF programme in March 2026, with technical talks continuing in September. Gabon has also maintained market access and repaid a $605 million Eurobond maturity in May 2025. An IMF-backed programme would anchor fiscal reform and unlock budget support targeted at 600 billion CFA francs for 2027, improving payment discipline and creating room for private and DFI-backed partnerships in the PNCD's projects.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Public debt and financing needs	Debt has risen with expansionary spending; Fitch rates Gabon CCC- and Moody's Caa2, raising the cost of sovereign borrowing	The September 2026 debt audit, PFM reforms and an expected IMF programme provide a credible path; investors can favour projects with DFI co-finance or private offtake revenue
Payment arrears	Government arrears reached $792 million at end-October 2025, which can delay payments to contractors and suppliers	Use escrow accounts, DFI or export-credit guarantees and milestone payment structures; arrears clearance is a stated IMF priority
Oil dependence and maturing fields	Oil provides 40–50% of government revenue and some onshore fields are ageing	Diversification into manganese processing, iron ore, wood and agriculture is accelerating, with oil output budgeted to rise 4.1% in 2027 and new LNG capacity planned
CEMAC foreign-exchange regulations	BEAC approval is needed for larger FX transactions and export proceeds must be repatriated within 150 days; access to FX for investment remittances has recently been tightened	Engage BEAC-licensed banks early, document transactions fully and consider SEZ status, which provides for full repatriation; the euro peg removes currency volatility
Local content and state participation	Rules limit foreign staff in the oil sector to 10% and give the State equity rights in petroleum and mining, while the new Constitution restricts foreign ownership in some sectors	Build local partnerships and training into project design from the outset; state participation also aligns government and investor interests
Governance and contract transparency	Gabon ranked 135th of 180 on Transparency International's 2024 index,	Rely on ICSID membership, the New York Convention and OHADA commercial law;

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	and extractive licensing has lacked transparency	reforms on governance and the business climate are part of IMF discussions
Transport infrastructure	Exports rely heavily on the single Trans-Gabon Railway, and landslides disrupted manganese and wood shipments in 2023	Railway upgrades are a national priority, creating openings in rail, road and port investment; build logistics contingency into export plans

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Gabon's risk profile combines strong natural-resource endowments, low inflation, a euro-pegged currency and a political transition that has been completed on schedule with fiscal pressures that the government is actively addressing. The sovereign's CCC-range ratings and accumulated arrears are the key considerations for any investor exposed to government payments, and the IMF has urged that higher oil revenues be used to clear arrears and rebuild buffers. The September 2026 debt audit, the January 2026 public financial management system and ongoing IMF negotiations point to a reform path that would improve payment discipline and unlock concessional finance. CEMAC exchange regulations are a compliance matter rather than a barrier, and are best handled with experienced local banks and counsel. Investors with private revenue streams, export earnings or DFI backing are well placed, while contractors to the State should use secure payment structures until an IMF programme is in place.

MARKET ACCESS

Gabon is a member of the Central African Economic and Monetary Community (CEMAC), sharing the BEAC and the euro-pegged CFA franc with five neighbours, and of the Economic Community of Central African States (ECCAS), which is headquartered in Libreville. It has been a WTO member since 1995, rejoined the African Union's full activities in April 2025, and has bilateral investment treaties with Belgium-Luxembourg, China, Germany, Italy, South Korea, Morocco, Romania and Spain. Oil, manganese and timber account for around 97% of exports, with China the leading destination. Goods move through Owendo port, fed by the Trans-Gabon Railway, and through Port-Gentil for oil and gas, and the coming iron ore and LNG projects will broaden the export base and the markets it serves.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Presidency of the Republic (Brice Clotaire Oligui Nguema)	Sets the national development agenda, including the PNCD 2026–2030 and the push for local processing of natural resources	Primary reference point for Gabon's strategic and reform direction
ANPI-Gabon	National investment promotion agency running the single window for company set-up, SME support and PPPs	Standard first point of contact for market entry and incentives
Ministry of Economy, Finance, Debt and State Holdings	Leads the budget, the debt audit and the negotiation of a new IMF programme	Key counterpart for fiscal outlook, state payments and PPP structuring
Bank of Central African States (BEAC)	Regional central bank setting monetary policy and foreign-exchange regulations for CEMAC	Essential for capital transfers, repatriation and banking matters
Gabon Oil Company (GOC)	National oil company with rights to participate in petroleum contracts and co-lead of the Port-Gentil LNG project	Central partner for oil and gas engagement
GSEZ (Arise IIP and the Republic of Gabon)	Operates the Nkok, Ikolo and Mpassa-Lebombi zones with dedicated administrative and fiscal status	Preferred route for manufacturing and processing investment
Comilog (Eramet group, with state participation)	Gabon's leading manganese producer, operating at Moanda with metallurgical	Key reference for mining, processing and rail logistics

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
	processing	

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

ANPI-Gabon brings together more than 20 public and private bodies, including the Chamber of Commerce, and the High Council for Investment, created in 2017, provides a formal platform for public-private dialogue. GSEZ and its partner Arise IIP host a sizeable international investor community at Nkok and are a practical source of insight on operating conditions. The World Bank, the African Development Bank and the IMF are closely engaged on public finances, governance and growth, and their programmes are an important route to co-financing. Major operators such as Eramet, Perenco and Gabon Oil Company provide useful intelligence on the extractive and energy sectors, and the national budget cycle and PNCD project pipeline are the main reference points for upcoming opportunities.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Gabon suits investors with a long-term view of natural-resource value chains and the patience to work within a reforming fiscal framework: mining and metals investors in manganese, iron ore and downstream processing; energy investors in oil, gas and the new LNG segment; timber, agro-industry and manufacturing investors using the GSEZ zones' tax-free status and full repatriation; and infrastructure investors in rail, port, road and power projects under the PNCD, ideally alongside development finance institutions. Investors relying on government payments should structure contracts with secure payment mechanisms, while those with export revenues benefit from the stability of the euro-pegged currency.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage ANPI-Gabon and assess sector incentives
Use the single window to confirm current incentives under the investment code and the relevant sector code before committing capital.

STEP 2: Evaluate GSEZ zone status for processing and manufacturing
Compare Nkok, Ikolo and Mpassa-Lebombi for tax-free operation, duty-free equipment and full repatriation of funds.

STEP 3: Plan foreign-exchange and repatriation flows with BEAC rules in mind
Work with BEAC-licensed banks and local counsel to secure approvals and meet export-proceeds repatriation requirements from day one.

STEP 4: Track the IMF programme and debt-audit follow-up
Monitor progress towards an IMF-backed programme, which would support arrears clearance and unlock budget support, and time state-linked contracts accordingly.

STEP 5: Partner with DFIs and national champions on PNCD projects
Pair with the World Bank, AfDB or export-credit agencies, and with partners such as Gabon Oil Company or Comilog, to de-risk infrastructure, mining and energy investments.